

Battery settings: diagnose, don't guess

Battery complaints are usually emotional. “This phone’s battery is terrible.” Maybe. But maybe the real problem is poor network signal, one rogue app, high brightness, constant hotspot use, background sync, gaming heat, or a social media app refreshing all day.

Open Battery. Check usage by app. If one app consumes unusually high battery compared to your actual use, investigate. Restrict background battery use if needed. But be careful with messaging, email, calendar, banking and security apps. Aggressive battery restrictions can delay notifications.

Battery Saver is useful, but understand what it does. It may reduce background activity, limit visual effects, delay sync and restrict some features. Use it deliberately, not permanently. If your phone offers adaptive battery, leave it on unless it causes problems. Android’s developer summary for Android 16 also points to ongoing work around performance and battery management, including better job introspection and system health APIs for apps and developers.

Search for Charging protection, Battery protection or Optimised charging if your phone supports it. Some brands can limit charging behaviour to improve long-term battery health. This is useful if you keep the phone plugged in overnight or at a desk.

Storage settings: free space is performance insurance

A phone with nearly full storage becomes unpleasant. Apps update poorly, camera recording fails, WhatsApp becomes bloated, downloads vanish into confusion, and the system has less room to breathe.

Open Storage. Look at categories: apps, photos, videos, audio, documents, system, temporary files and other. Then clean intelligently. Do not install random “phone booster” apps. Use Android’s built-in storage manager or the Files by Google app if available.

Start with videos, WhatsApp media, duplicate downloads, old APKs and large forwarded files. In India, WhatsApp is often the true storage villain. Family groups, school groups, office groups and society groups can quietly fill a phone with greetings, PDFs, memes and videos no one asked for.

Search Storage manager. Turn on automatic cleanup only if you understand what it removes. Always check before deleting local copies of photos if cloud backup is not complete.

Default apps: choose the tools you trust

Default apps decide what opens when you tap a link, make a call, receive SMS, open a PDF, use voice assistance or tap a launcher button. Search Default apps.

Set your default browser intentionally. Set your SMS app carefully, especially if you rely on OTP detection. Set your phone app, caller ID behaviour, assistant and home app. If you installed a

THE 25 SETTINGS TO CHECK TODAY

Search and review these one by one: Android version, Security update, Google Play system update, App notifications, Notification history, Lock screen notifications, Do Not Disturb, Display size, Dark mode, Refresh rate, Battery usage, Battery Saver, Storage, Data Saver, Wi-Fi calling, SIM manager, Hotspot password, Private DNS, Permission manager, Privacy Dashboard, Default apps, Unknown app installs, Play Protect, Backup, and Find Hub.

third-party launcher, know how to switch back to the original launcher before experimenting too much.

Also check Opening links. Some apps hijack links aggressively. You can control whether supported links open in apps or the browser. This is useful when shopping links, social links or news links keep opening in unwanted apps.

Find Hub: prepare before the phone is lost

Nobody wants to configure lost-phone features after losing the phone. Google’s Find Hub can help locate, lock, erase or play a sound on a lost Android device. Google’s own Find Hub page describes the ability to find, lock, erase or play a sound on a lost Android device, while the Play Store listing notes support for locating phones, tablets, headphones and accessories, including some offline-finding capabilities. Google’s Android help also says Find Hub allows users to locate, secure and erase lost Android devices, and that encrypted recent locations can help through the Find Hub network.

Search Find Hub. Make sure your device can be located. Confirm that location is enabled, the Google account is correct, and the device has a screen lock. Also check whether your family members know how to help you access Find Hub from another device.

This is not only about theft. It is about leaving the phone in an auto, misplacing it at a wedding, forgetting it in a press room, or watching it disappear between sofa cushions while it is on silent.

You do not need to change everything. You need to know where everything is.

That is the real point of this chapter. Android mastery is not about memorising every menu. It is about refusing to be helpless inside your own phone. Settings is where Android stops being a sealed appliance and becomes something you can shape. A casual user waits for the phone to become annoying, unsafe, slow or confusing. A power user opens Settings before that happens. **d**